

straight lines. He punches the pause button to tell Mom they have to miss Monica's violin recital because an important client invited them to Opening Day at Dodger Stadium. Mom asks him to talk to Alex about the dangers of driving under the influence. While he's at it, he should also say something to Alex about his bad grades. Mom tells him about her appointment with Alex's counselor.

At 10:00 P.M. Mom leaves to pick up Monica at a friend's house. Mom and Monica drop by the Superscoop to see Alex and remind him that he has to take Monica to ballet class the following afternoon. Alex had forgotten about it. Mom and Monica buy a half-gallon of ice cream and return home. Monica kisses her father, scoops a huge bowl of ice cream, and goes up to her room to practice. She forgets to model her new black dress for her parents.

Mom and Dad eat ice cream and go over their weekend to-do list. They finalize the invitation list for their annual spring barbecue party. They coordinate their calendars.

Alex arrives home after everyone is asleep. He punches the night sequence in the burglar alarm and wakes Mom up to tell her he's home.

Does the Doe family sound anything like yours? Mom, Dad, Alex, and Monica rush from one activity to another. They have a car for every driver. When they see one another they coordinate schedules rather than spend "quality time" together. They have a large home with modern conveniences. Two incomes go into paying for it. Yet, the four of them rarely have time to enjoy the house together.

In retirement this family can shed some of that weighty infrastructure. Dad, Mom, Alex, and Monica will live at a slower pace, have more time together, and do without expensive gadgetry. They'll make some sacrifices. But they'll be out of the pressure cooker that destroys so many American families.